Srivasa Pandita

Шриваса Пандит · @srivasa

Foremost Among the Devotees

Srivasa Pandita, also called Srivasa Thakura, is one of the five who make up the Pancha-tattva, and within it he is the first of the pure devotees. His name is renowned as that of a herald, the very “mouth” of the truth of pure devotion to Gaura-Hari. Krishnadasa Kaviraja opens his “Chaitanya-charitamrita” with obeisances to the Lord's associates, and of Srivasa he says:

“There are many saintly devotees of the Lord, but the chief among them is Srivasa Thakura. I humbly offer him thousands of obeisances.” (CC, Adi 1.38)

Srivasa's house in Navadvipa was the stage for most of Mahaprabhu's Navadvipa pastimes. Here the Lord first revealed His divine form to a devotee, here for a whole year the kirtana went on behind closed doors night after night, here took place the Mahaprakasha and Nityananda's Vyasa-puja. And Srivasa himself, with his family, his servants and even the animals of his household, shows to what kind of home the Lord's mercy comes: to a home given over to Him entirely.

Brothers from Shrihatta

Srivasa's family came from Shrihatta (Sylhet). There, as the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” says, his brother Srirama, Chandrashekhara and Murari Gupta also appeared. There were four brothers: Srivasa; Srirama, that is, Rama Pandita, affectionately called Ramai; Shripati; and Shrinidhi, who is also called Shrikanta. All four took part in the Lord's pastimes, and the three younger ones lived with Srivasa in Navadvipa. Of their father we know only from a single tradition: his name was Jaladhara Pandita, he was a Vedic brahmana, and the eldest of his sons was Nalina Pandita.[1] At first the brothers lived in Shrihatta; later, seeking the company of devotees, they moved to the bank of the Ganga, to Navadvipa.

Srivasa built a house by the Ganga, not far from the house of Jagannatha Mishra in Navadvipa-Mayapur. His wife's name was Malini Devi. With them lived Narayani, the daughter of one of Srivasa's brothers,[2] the mother of Vrindavana Dasa Thakura, author of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata.” Her husband, Vaikuntha Dasa Vipra, died while she was carrying her son; Vrindavana Dasa was born in 1507. Part of his childhood he spent in Mamgachhi, on Modadruma-dvipa of Navadvipa, by the Bhagirathi — in the parental home of Malini Devi, to which Malini herself returned in her old age; there his Deities, Gaura-Nitai, are served to this day, and the place of his childhood play is shown.[3] Srivasa himself had a son, an only son, who died as a child; of him we shall speak below.[4]

The brothers, their servants and all their household gave themselves forever to the feet of Mahaprabhu. Gaurasundara was everything to them, and they knew no other gods:

“These four brothers, their whole family and household served Lord Sri Chaitanya. Apart from Gaurachandra they worshipped no other gods or goddesses.” (CC, Adi 10.11)

Srivasa's appearance day is Krishna-ashtami, the eighth day of the dark fortnight of the month of Chaitra; so our calendar also marks it, in the month of Vishnu. His disappearance day is Krishna-dashami of the month of Vamana, that is, Ashadha. The biographies name neither the year of his appearance nor the year of his departure.[5]

Kirtana Before the Lord's Appearance

Before coming Himself, the Lord sends to earth His senior associates — those who will be His father, mother and teachers. Krishnadasa Kaviraja names Srivasa among them (CC, Adi 13.52–55), and so it is

said that Chaitanya, Advaita and Nityananda came together with Srivasa and others to give the world hari-bhakti. Srivasa, Haridasa and others were sent ahead of the Lord.

The world at that time was languishing without Krishna. No one understood who a Vaishnava was or why sankirtana was needed; people attached to body and home, slaves of their senses, hungry for sons and wealth — the pashandis — mocked the Vaishnavas. The four brothers grieved over this and did not sleep at night: they sang the name of Hari loudly in their home. Three times a day, at the three sandhyas, they worshipped Krishna, and every day they bathed in the Ganga. In the house by the Ganga, Srivasa, together with kindred souls — Advaita Acharya, Haridasa Thakura and others — sang the name of Krishna, calling for the coming appearance of Gaura-Hari.

The leader of the Navadvipa Vaishnavas then was Advaita Acharya, who had returned to Bengal: around him gathered Srivasa, Chandrashekhara and Gangadasa. Advaita also had a house in Navadvipa, not far from Srivasa's, and there he would speak of Krishna until dawn with the devotees headed by Srivasa. The brothers went to him to hear the “Bhagavatam,” to sing nama-sankirtana and to help in the Vaishnavas' affairs; when Haridasa came to Navadvipa, Advaita, Srivasa and all the others welcomed him with joy. All of them were close friends of Jagannatha Mishra, and by their devotion they sensed that Krishna Himself would soon appear in his home.

Hindus hostile to the Vaishnavas decided that Srivasa would ruin the whole village: should the Muslim ruler, an enemy of sanatana-dharma, learn of his kirtana, all Navadvipa would suffer. They conspired to tear down his house and drive the brahmana out of town at once. Hearing of this, Advaita grew angry and made a firm vow: soon he would bring Krishna down to Navadvipa to crush the pashandis. “Listen, Shuklambara, Gangadasa, Srivasa,” he said, “I shall bring Krishna before everyone's eyes.”

Seeing the sufferings of souls in the age of Kali, the devotees prayed that God Himself would come. And Hari appeared — in the house of Jagannatha Mishra in Mayapur, on the full moon of the month of Phalguna in the year 1407 of the Shaka era (1486). Advaita understood Who had come, went to Srivasa and the others, and revealed to them the meaning of this appearance.

Nimai's Childhood

When a son was born to Shachi, Srivasa in ecstasy bathed in the Ganga, arranged hari-sankirtana and gave away many gifts. Malini, together with the wife of Chandrashekhara Acharyaratna, brought to Shachi's house sindura, turmeric, oil, khai (puffed rice), bananas and other fruits, and performed the auspicious rites.

Malini was Shachi's constant friend: they delighted in each other's company, and after the birth Malini tended Shachi like a nurse. She always raised and cared for the boy tenderly, and in their love for Him she and Shachi were of one heart. Srivasa, for his part, was at Jagannatha Mishra's house so often that he was called his host's shadow. Srivasa and Malini helped to raise Nimai and taught Him much, and Gaurasundara honoured them as a second father and mother.

Then came the time of the pastimes of learning. Nimai would put tricky questions of logic to Srivasa and other devotees, and Srivasa, seeing Him from afar, would hurry off another way. Mukunda, Srivasa and others who knew the taste of bhakti avoided idle debates with Nimai Pandita; listening to Him argue with Gadadhara and Mukunda, the devotees only sighed: “If only such a scholar would become a devotee!” They could not recognise their Lord in Nimai: what concealed Him from them was the Lord's yogamaya, His lila-shakti, which for the sake of His pastimes enchants even those turned toward Him.[6] And Srivasa prayed to Krishna that love for Krishna would awaken in Nimai.

Nimai Himself, the Lord of the devotees, would bow to the ground on meeting Srivasa and other Vaishnavas, honouring the devotees, and they would bless Him: “May You have devotion to Krishna.”

The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” explains why He did so:

“The Lord respectfully accepted the blessings of the devotees, knowing that devotional service to Lord Krishna can be attained only by the power of the Vaishnavas' blessings.” (CB, Adi 12.46)

Srivasa often said to Him: “Why waste time on worldly learning? The essence of all knowledge is service to Krishna.” Nimai would reply that He was fortunate, since the Vaishnavas wished Him well: He would teach a little longer, and then go to a pure Vaishnava to learn devotion to Krishna. Once they met in the street. Nimai was walking with His students, finely dressed, with tilaka on His forehead, His lips red with betel and a book in His hand. Srivasa could not hold back a smile: “People study in order to know devotion to Krishna; without it, what is learning for? Do not waste time — serve Krishna.” Nimai smiled in reply: “By your mercy I shall certainly serve Krishna” (CB, Adi 12.250–252). Thus, even in the days of Nimai's schoolboy pranks, Srivasa instructed Him: the object of knowledge is Krishna and devotion to Krishna.

“I Would Wish Such a Disorder for Myself”

From Gaya, where Nimai received the mantra from Ishvara Puri, He returned changed: signs of intoxication with love of God began to appear in Him. Shachi was frightened that her son had lost his mind — from outside it looked like an illness, a “disorder of the airs” (vayu-vyadhi) — and sent for Srivasa and other Vaishnavas. Nimai was circling the tulasi; seeing Srivasa, He remembered Krishna and fell unconscious.

Srivasa understood at once that this was no illness but transcendental mahabhava: the desire of his heart had been fulfilled. He comforted Shachi and asked her to tell no one what great love had manifested in her son. And Nimai asked him: “Everyone says My humours are disordered. What do you think?” Srivasa laughed: “I would wish such a disorder for myself! Strong feelings of devotion have awakened in You — this is Krishna's mercy.” The Lord embraced him: “Had you too said that I was ill, I would have drowned Myself in the Ganga this very day” (CB, Madhya 2.113–117).

Now Nimai sang the name loudly day and night in His own house and in Srivasa's. The pashandis complained that they could not sleep and reviled the devotees, and Srivasa most of all: “That brahmana Srivasa is behind it all! Four brothers shouting for their bread.” They spread a rumour that by the king's order two boats were coming to seize the singers; they proposed throwing Srivasa's house into the Ganga and binding him and handing him over to the authorities (CB, Madhya 2.229–238). According to the “Chaitanya-mangala” of Lochana Dasa, a brahmana who wanted to frighten Srivasa and stop the kirtana was bewildered by the Lord's maya.

The biographies see a lesson in this: Srivasa as if deliberately drew the pashandis' abuse upon himself to teach that a devotee endures the reproaches of society and neighbours, humbler than a blade of grass and more tolerant than a tree, and does not give up kirtana, while the Lord always protects one who has surrendered to Him.

“Whom Are You Worshipping?”

Srivasa shut the door of his temple and began to worship Nrisimhadeva.[7] The Lord, knowing his heart from within, came to his house and began kicking the door of the room where the household Deity stood — the door flew open — and roared:

“Whom are you worshipping? On Whom are you meditating? Know that the One you worship now stands before you!” (CB, Madhya 2.258)

Srivasa's absorption was broken. Before him sat Gaura-Hari holding conch, disc, club and lotus in four hands, slapping His left side and roaring. One biography says that He sat in the hero's posture (virasana)

and showed the form of Nrisimha with the four emblems of Vishnu; another, that He entered the room of the Vishnu Deity, boldly sat on the altar and revealed His four-armed form. Srivasa was struck dumb with wonder.

“Your loud kirtana and Advaita's roaring,” said the Lord, “have brought Me from Vaikuntha together with My associates. Because the devotees are persecuted I have left Vaikuntha. I shall protect the righteous and destroy the wicked — do not worry. Have you still not understood that I have come? Recite My praises.” And again: “If you want fearlessness, sing My sankirtana.”

Srivasa rose in love, joined his palms and glorified Vishvambhara to his heart's content with the prayer of Brahma from the “Bhagavatam.” By one account, he fell prostrate and bowed to Vishvambhara, the son of Shachi, in yellow cloth, with a garland of gunja and a peacock feather — “to Nimai, the student of Gangadasa” — and said that now his ancestors were delivered and his life fulfilled. The Lord, pleased, wished to show His form to Srivasa's wife, his children and all his household, and told him to serve His feet with his wife and ask for blessings. Srivasa and his family worshipped Vishvambhara's feet with everything they had prepared for the worship of Vishnu — fragrances, flowers, incense, lamps — and surrendered themselves to Him. The whole household received mercy.

Vishvambhara granted Srivasa complete fearlessness and promised that He would drive mad with love for Krishna even the Muslim king, hostile to bhakti, together with his whole retinue. Then Srivasa — bold of speech, a “maha-vakta” — raised his arms and said fearlessly: “I fear not even Time itself, which creates and destroys the world — what have I to fear in a house where Gaurasundara lives eternally?”

Narayani, Srivasa's four-year-old niece, was there too. The Lord said to her, “Krishna, Krishna!” — and the girl began to weep and fell senseless to the ground. The Lord gave her His prasada and blessed her with mercy, making her utter the holy name. Seeing her tears, Srivasa's wife and all the devotees wept with love, and Srivasa's courtyard was filled with prema. As the devotee is dear to the Lord, so the Lord is dear to the devotee.

That day in Srivasa's house the Lord gave darshana to all His eternal associates and devotees. The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” concludes:

“That Lord Whom the personified four Vedas long to see revealed Himself even to the servants and maidservants of Srivasa. What more can be said of Srivasa's magnanimity? The dust of his feet purifies the whole universe. Krishna appeared in the house of Vasudeva, but displayed His wonderful pastimes in the house of Nanda Maharaja. In the same way, though the Lord appeared in the house of Jagannatha Mishra, He performed His astonishing pastimes in the house of Srivasa Pandita.” (CB, Madhya 2.331–334)

Lochana Dasa in the “Chaitanya-mangala” tells of other pastimes in this house. Once, when the Lord came to Srivasa and his brothers, the devotees heard Krishna's flute; the Lord became absorbed in the mood of Radhika, laughing and weeping in the madness of separation, and a divine voice said: “Vishvambhara, You are the Lord Himself, descended to preach love for Krishna.” Another time the Lord showed here the form of Nrisimha and blessed Srivasa with mercy, and Srivasa performed His abhisheka. Here too was performed the “gada-puja,” the worship of Vishnu's club, to invoke the Lord's power against the godless.

Nityananda in Srivasa's House

One day Vishvambhara, having told of a dream in which He saw a great personality on the chariot of Baladeva, entered the mood of Balarama and began to roar: “Wine! Wine!” Srivasa replied: “The wine of Hari-rasa is Yours alone — whoever You give it to will receive it.” Nityananda meanwhile was living

secretly with Nandana Acharya. Having learned of His coming in a dream, Gaura sent Haridasa Thakura and Srivasa to search for Him:

“O Haridasa! O Srivasa Pandita! Go and look for anyone who has lately come to the town” (CB, Madhya 3.160)

For three praharas they went round Navadvipa — the homes of Vaishnavas, sannyasis, householders — and did not find the newcomer. Then Gaura Himself led everyone to Nandana's and revealed Nityananda to them.[8]

At the Lord's sign Srivasa recited a verse of the “Bhagavatam” — “barhāpīḍaṁ naṭa-vara-vapuḥ…” (Bhag. 10.21.5): Krishna, dressed as the best of dancers, with a crown of peacock feathers, enters the forest of Vrindavana. At once Nityananda displayed wondrous transformations of love — He fell unconscious, and all eight sattvika-bhavas appeared in Him — and Vishvambhara pressed Him to His chest. Srivasa begged Gaura to recite the verse again and again. Gaura and Nityananda praised each other and conversed in signs, and Srivasa said: “Just as people cannot understand how Hari and Hara, Madhava and Shankara, worship each other, so we cannot understand how Gaura and Nityananda glorify each other.”

Gaura proposed to Nityananda that He perform Vyasa-puja. Nityananda understood His hint, took Srivasa by the hand and said: “The Vyasa-puja will be in this brahmana's house.” Srivasa gladly took everything upon himself: he prepared the rite with fervour and obtained the manual “Vyasa-puja-paddhati.” A few days later, behind closed doors, the adhivasa-kirtana began. On the night of the adhivasa Mahaprabhu entered the mood of Baladeva, revealing Nityananda's oneness with Balarama, and called to Advaita: “Nara, Nara!” That same night Nityananda broke His staff and kamandalu in Srivasa's house; in the morning the Lord learned of it from Ramai, Srivasa's brother.

The acharya, the officiating priest, of the Vyasa-puja was Srivasa. He placed in Nityananda's hand a garland of forest flowers of wondrous fragrance and asked Him, reciting the mantras, to bow to Vyasadeva. Nityananda hesitated and looked around, and Srivasa complained to Gaura: “Your Shripada is not performing the puja!” Then Nityananda placed the garland on Gaura Himself,[9] and Gaura revealed a six-armed form — with Balarama's club and plough and the four emblems of Vishnu. Afterwards Mahaprabhu asked Srivasa for the offerings of the Vyasa-puja and distributed them Himself to everyone in the house, down to the servants and maidservants.

After the Vyasa-puja the Lord, in the mood of the Supreme, sent Ramai to Shantipur for Advaita: let him come to Srivasa-angana, “Srivasa's courtyard,” with his wife and everything needed for worship. Advaita, testing the Lord, first hid at Nandana's. The Lord ascended the couch of Vishnu in Srivasa's house — Nityananda held an umbrella over Him — revealed Advaita's intention to all, and sent Ramai again. Advaita came to Srivasa's house and bowed to the Lord; the “Chaitanya-mangala” also tells of this worship.

Nityananda settled with Srivasa in Mayapur and displayed here the childlike moods of Vraja. Srivasa was a father to Him, Malini a mother; she treated Him as her own son and fed Him with her own hands, and He was always drinking her milk: at the sight of Nityananda, transcendental maternal love made milk flow from her breasts. Srivasa-angana became the centre of the sankirtana of Chaitanya and Nityananda, and Nityananda, the avadhuta, was always in the ecstasy of love.

Once Gaura, wishing to test Srivasa's faith, said to him: “You are a brahmana — why do you keep this avadhuta? Who knows His caste and family? If you want to keep your caste, send Him away quickly.” Srivasa answered: “It does not befit You to test me so. Nityananda is Your second body. Whoever has worshipped You for even a day is dear to me as life, whoever he may be. Let Nityananda drink wine, keep company with a woman of another faith, ruin my caste, my life and my wealth — my faith in Him

will not waver."[10]

Then the Lord, of His own accord, unasked, blessed him: "Sooner will the goddess of fortune, Lakshmi, go begging from door to door than you will ever know want of anything. Whoever lives in your house, even a dog or a cat, will attain undivided devotion to Me. I entrust Nityananda to you. Take care of all His needs" (CB, Madhya 8.20–22). The occasion of the blessing was Srivasa's devotion to Nityananda and his unshakeable faith in Him.

Once Nityananda, in the mood of a cowherd boy of Vraja, threw off His cloth, tied it on His head and wandered swaying about the courtyard; Gaura dressed Him and, as if scolding, glorified Him. Another time a crow carried off from Srivasa's temple the brass cup used in the service of Krishna. Malini wept, knowing how angry her husband would be; Nityananda told the crow to return the cup, and it at once laid it before Malini.[11]

Here too, in Srivasa's house, the question of Nityananda's marriage was settled. According to the "Bhakti-ratnakara," a brahmana sent by Surya Dasa Sarakhela came to Navadvipa to Srivasa, with whom Nityananda was living; Srivasa rejoiced and passed the matter of the marriage to Nityananda Himself, and then Srivasa, Advaita, Chandrashekhara, Murari and others gathered and sang sankirtana.

Once, while Nityananda was wandering about Nadia, the Lord revealed His universal form in Srivasa's house. Nityananda, knowing it within, came to Srivasa's door and roared, and the Lord showed Him the form of countless universes.

The Nightly Kirtana Behind Closed Doors

Mahaprabhu announced: from now on there would be unbroken sankirtana every night, followed by a bath in the Ganga. As the place of the nightly kirtana He chose Srivasa's house; sometimes the kirtana was held in the house of Chandrashekhara Acharya (CB, Madhya 8.110–112). It began on the day of Sri Hari-vasara, Ekadashi: on the blessed ground of Srivasa's courtyard rang out "Gopala! Govinda!", and from dawn Vishvambhara danced (CB, Madhya 8.138–140).[12] Mahaprabhu would now sing the refrain "Hari o Rama Rama," now cry out in joy "Jitam! Jitam!" — "Victory!" — and the devotees echoed Him.

They sang behind closed doors, only with intimates; no unbeliever in Nadia was admitted. Taking part in the kirtanas at Srivasa's were Haridasa, Mukunda, Gangadasa, Hiranya, Vanamali, Vijaya, Nandana, Jagadananda, Buddhimanta Khan, Pundarika Vidyanidhi, Sadashiva, Gopinatha, Jagadisha, Shriman, Shridhara, Vakreshvara, Shrigarbha, Shuklambara, Kashishvara, Govinda Ghosha, Vasudeva Datta and many others. When the Lord, after Gaya, gathered the devotees for kirtana in Srivasa-angana, Advaita brought Sita Thakurani to Mayapur as well. Srivasa, Haridasa and Vakreshvara danced in the kirtana.

Thousands of hostile people clamoured at the locked doors. What was not said about the kirtana! That behind the door they chanted mantras, summoned five maidens and feasted; they threatened: "Tomorrow we shall drive this brahmana Srivasa out of Nadia, tear down his house and throw it into the river" (CB, Madhya 8.241–244, 265, 267–272). Mahaprabhu and His associates paid no attention to the abuse. Srivasa remained deaf to it, and day and night, absorbed with Gaura in the taste of Krishna, he sang: "Jaya Krishna Murari Mukunda Banamali."

As the night of the rasa-lila seemed a moment to the gopis, so the nights of kirtana at Srivasa's seemed short to the Lord and His associates, and the kirtanas behind locked doors went on every night for a whole year. Once, at the end of such a night, Mahaprabhu placed all the shalagramas on His lap, sat on the altar, revealed a wondrous form and accepted the devotees' offerings.

The Mahaprakasha

The greatest revelation in this house was the Mahaprakasha. Gaura came to Srivasa together with Nityananda, and at His sign the kirtana began. After the night's kirtana He entered the Vishnu temple, took the shalagramas and sat on the couch of Vishnu; He cast off the mood of a devotee and declared openly that He is Vishnu, spoke of His present incarnation and asked for food. To accept the service of all who had taken shelter of Him, He sat for seven praharas — twenty-one hours, whence this pastime is called “sat-prahariya” — on the throne of Vishnu in Srivasa's temple. At His sign He was given, as the King of kings, an abhisheka according to all the injunctions, with the mantras of the “Purusha-sukta”; according to the “Chaitanya-mangala,” it was Srivasa himself who performed it. After the bath the Lord was worshipped and glorified with the ten-syllable Gopala-mantra. He stretched out His feet, accepted flowers and gifts, granted all their desires and appeared in the forms of all the previous avataras.

To each He spoke of his past. He called Gangadasa and reminded him of the river crossing; Murari saw Him in the form of Rama; He called Shridhara too; Pundarika Vidyanidhi was there, and Gadadhara saw it all. Srivasa's servants and maidservants were blessed to carry water for Gaura-Hari's bath — the fruit of serving so pure a devotee as their master.

One of the maidservants was called Duhkhi, “the unhappy one.” Every morning she carried water from the Ganga for the Lord's bath and watched His dance with tears. The Lord, seeing her, said Himself: “More water, bring water!” — and asked Srivasa who was carrying the water. Then He gave her a new name — Sukhi, “the happy one”: she who serves Bhagavan and the Vaishnavas cannot be unhappy. From then on Srivasa ceased to see Sukhi as a servant and every day entrusted her with carrying Ganga water for Mahaprabhu's bath.

That day the Lord reminded Srivasa of an old incident. Before the Lord's appearance, Srivasa, a rasika-bhakta, had gone to hear the “Bhagavatam” from Devananda Pandita, and at the very first verse he fell to the ground in love and rolled on the floor weeping. Devananda's foolish students shouted, “A madman, out with him!” and dragged him out of the door; they came to their teacher only for learning and did not understand that the sattvika-bhavas in Srivasa's spiritual body purify the world, but took him for an ordinary emotional man. Devananda saw this and did not stop them — and so became a party to the offence. Srivasa told no one of his hurt and went home. Now the Lord asked him: “Do you remember?” — and Srivasa in amazement fell at His feet. Srivasa's ecstasy on hearing the “Bhagavatam” is a sign of the highest taste of devotion, and the mockery of the pashandis comes from want of faith.

The Lord called each of the devotees separately and blessed him with mercy — He did not call only Mukunda Datta, the constant singer of Srivasa-angana, the chief lead singer on hari-vasara and at the Mahaprakasha. Srivasa interceded for him. The Lord replied: “Mukunda is not worthy to see Me. He keeps company with every community and supports their doctrines: now he holds a straw between his teeth, now he takes up a stick — with one hand he grasps the feet, with the other the throat.” Mukunda resolved to give up his body if he did not receive Gaura's mercy, and through Srivasa asked whether he would ever see the Lord. Through Srivasa came the answer: “After ten million births.” Mukunda danced for joy — and the Lord said that those births had passed in a moment, and allowed him to see Him.

All these manifestations of the “maha-maha-prakasha” took place in Srivasa's house. Vrindavana Dasa says: in Navadvipa hundreds of ascetics, sannyasis, yogis and jnanis study the “Gita” and the “Bhagavatam” in vain, while Srivasa with his wife, children and servants — and even the dogs and cats of his house — received what sannyasis and ascetics will not attain even in a ten-millionth part.

Narayani, four years old, lived with Srivasa and was blessed with the remnants of Mahaprabhu's meal. That is why among Vaishnavas she is known to this day as “Sri-chaitanya-avashesha-patri,” “she who partakes of Chaitanya's remnants”; and by the mercy of that prasada, it is said, Vrindavana Dasa, an

incarnation of Vyasa, was later born to her.

Srivasa's clothes were sewn by a Muslim tailor, and the Lord blessed him too:

“A Muslim tailor sewed clothes for Srivasa Thakura. Lord Chaitanya bestowed special mercy on him by revealing His eternal form. The tailor cried ‘I see! I see!’ and began to dance like a madman, intoxicated with divine love. Thus he became the best of Vaishnavas.” (CC, Adi 17.231–232)

This house saw many other pastimes. Here the Lord revealed the four-armed form of Narayana and began calling for Garuda — Murari with a roar took the form of the king of birds, and the Lord sat on his shoulders. Here too Murari bowed first to the Lord and then to Nityananda, and the Lord pointed out his mistake. Here took place the pastime with Shuklambara's bag of rice (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 12). The chief dancer in the performances in Srivasa's house was Vakreshvara; once he danced here without a break for seventy-two hours (CC, Adi 10.17). The “Chaitanya-mangala” tells how the Lord explained the hidden meaning of the name “Srivasa”; how, appearing in the form of Rama, He told Rama Pandita to serve Srivasa; how He spoke to Srivasa of the dharmas of the ages — in the age of Kali the best of them is sankirtana; how Srivasa asked about the greatness of Advaita, and the Lord expounded to him the Advaita-tattva.

Those Who Offended Srivasa

Gopala Chapala, a garrulous bhattacharya, one night, while the kirtana was going on behind Srivasa's locked doors, left at his door everything needed for the worship of Bhavani (Kali): banana leaves, hibiscus flowers, red sandalwood, a pot of wine and meat. In the morning Srivasa opened the door, saw this and, laughing, said loudly to everyone around: “Look, I worship Bhavani every night! Here is my glory — I am a shakta.” He said it in jest. The respectable people of Navadvipa, distressed, called a sweeper, threw everything away and purified the place with water and cow dung.

For the offence at Srivasa's feet Gopala was struck with leprosy — festering sores covered his whole body. He lived under a tree by the Ganga, and when the Lord came there to bathe, he begged Him for deliverance. The Lord answered in anger:

“‘O wicked envier of devotees! Expect no forgiveness from Me, I shall not save you! Let worms devour you for tens of millions of lives.’” (CC, Adi 17.51)

For having made Srivasa out to be a worshipper of Bhavani, said the Lord, he would spend ten million births in hell (CC, Adi 17.52) — in the hell called Raurava, the biographies specify.

Years passed. After His sannyasa, on the way to Nilachala, the Lord came to Kuliya, and Gopala again begged for forgiveness. This time the Lord told him to ask forgiveness of Srivasa — and by Srivasa's mercy the offence was removed. That is why Kuliya is called “the place where offences are forgiven”; it is the present town of Navadvip (Koladvipa). Forgiveness must be asked of the very devotee one has offended.

A similar case took place in Shantipura, also on the way to Nilachala. A man tormented by leprosy came to the Lord. The Lord said that for an offence at Srivasa's feet he would suffer endlessly in the hell called Kumbhipaka; and when he repented, the Lord told him to ask Srivasa's forgiveness — the only remedy for vaishnava-aparadha. Srivasa forgave him. The “Chaitanya-mangala” too tells how an envious brahmana struck with leprosy begged forgiveness for an offence against a Vaishnava and was saved by Srivasa's mercy.

Devananda too had offended Srivasa. “Many days later” the Lord met him in the town — by the embankment of Visharada in Kuliya (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 12.2976–2977) — and rebuked him severely: a great expounder of the “Bhagavatam,” learned, an ascetic, renounced from birth — yet he had

indulged students hostile to Srivasa and had lost the right to read the “Bhagavatam,” for he had no faith in the Vaishnavas:

“Anyone who makes a distinction between Me, My servant and the book ‘Bhagavatam’ surely brings ruin upon himself.” (CB, Madhya 21.18)

“This reader, who keeps silent about loving service to God, knows nothing at all; see how I shall tear up his book today,” the Lord went on (CB, Madhya 21.20–21). “To see such a devotee as Srivasa, even the Ganga came down from Hara's head to earth as a river; the offence you committed by driving him out through your students has turned you away from God.” The Lord, who had learned of the offence already at the Mahaprakasha, long remained indifferent to Devananda; later He told him to ask forgiveness at Srivasa's feet — for the book-Bhagavata and the devotee-Bhagavata are one. Devananda came to Srivasa, who embraced and forgave him.[13] At the very time the Lord was rebuking Devananda, Saranga Thakura met Him in a street of Navadvipa.

All these stories teach one thing: an offence against a Vaishnava is removed only by the forgiveness of the one offended — whether Gopala Chapala, the leper of Shantipura or Devananda.

Who Has No Place at the Kirtana

One evening Srivasa's mother-in-law, without telling him, hid in a corner of the room under an upturned basket (a dool), hoping to watch the kirtana. The Lord was dancing — and suddenly began to repeat: “Why is there no joy for Me today? Is an outsider hiding here?” Srivasa searched the room, found no one, and asked the Lord to sing and dance freely. Again the Lord said there was no joy, and some devotees began to blame themselves. Srivasa searched more carefully and found his mother-in-law; she was led out by the hair,[14] and the Lord danced joyfully.

The Lord Himself sought out Srivasa's wife, son, servants and maidservants, even his dogs and cats, to give them His prasada — but the mother-in-law, lacking simplicity, was left without the mercy of both the devotee and the Lord: the daughter received prasada, the mother did not. The lesson of this story: the Lord is merciful to the guileless; bodily kinship with a great devotee does not yet admit one to the society of devotees, and in bhakti bodily and social ties are no measure. Only those who have received His mercy may see the Lord's pastimes.

There lived in Navadvipa a brahmachari, an ascetic of holy life who drank only milk. He earnestly begged Srivasa to let him see the Lord's dance, and Srivasa, considering him sinless, secretly left him in the house. The all-knowing Lord said: “There is no joy in My heart — there is an outsider in the house.” Srivasa answered in fear: there was no pashandi here, only a sinless milk-drinking brahmachari quietly waiting to see His dance. The Lord grew angry: “Take him out at once! Drinking milk gives no right to see My dance. A chandala who has taken shelter of Me will receive more mercy than a sannyasi without surrender. Asceticism, renunciation and celibacy are displayed even by asuras — only surrender leads to Me.” The brahmachari went out in fear, but begged at least to look upon the Lord. The rebuke opened his eyes; he praised his good fortune, and the Lord called him over, placed His feet on his head and told him not to be proud of his austerity. Neither asceticism, nor milk, nor celibacy gives the right to the Lord's dance — the path to Him is surrender alone.

The “Chaitanya-mangala” tells it differently: a brahmana was not admitted to the nightly kirtana and cursed the Lord: “May Your worldly happiness perish!” — and the Lord gladly accepted the curse and consoled the repentant brahmana: it was what He Himself desired.

Other Pastimes in Navadvipa

Gaurasundara wished to enact the pastimes of Vraja in the house of Chandrashekhara Acharya and said who would take which part; at His direction Buddhimanta Khan assigned the roles. The Lord took for Himself the part of Mahalakshmi and warned that only those who had conquered their senses might watch. Advaita and Srivasa answered sadly: “We have not conquered our senses — how then can we watch?” The Lord smiled and said that today all would become great yogis and nothing would disturb them — and that without Advaita and Srivasa He would not dance at all.

Advaita was the jester (vidushaka), Haridasa the watchman (kotoval), Nityananda an old woman, Gadadhara a gopi; the Lord came out as Rukmini and at the end as Adya-shakti, the primordial energy. Haridasa called out to everyone, “Awake! Awake!” — and Srivasa danced in the dress of Narada (CB, Madhya 18.100). Srivasa came on stage as Narada, and Ramai as his disciple and companion; thus, under the guise of a play, they revealed their former forms and the truth about Gaura. Srivasa-Narada said: “I have travelled the universes wishing to see Krishna; in Vaikuntha the doors are shut and the house is empty. I heard that Krishna has come to Nadia and, dressed as Lakshmi, will dance.” Shachi came to watch with Vishnupriya, and the Vaishnavas with their families; and Shachi, seeing Srivasa in the form of Narada, fainted with wonder (“Bhakti-ratnakara” 12.1949–1952). According to the “Chaitanya-mangala,” Srivasa in the form of Narada also glorified Gadadhara Pandita.

Once Vishvambhara, walking through the town, smelled wine at a drunkard's house and, in the mood of Baladeva, called Srivasa: He wanted to go in. Srivasa seized His feet and would not let Him. “Are there prohibitions even for Me?” asked the Lord. Srivasa replied: “You are the father of the world. If You do not keep the rules to teach people, who will? Slanderers who do not understand Your pastimes will suffer birth after birth. Have pity on the souls — and if You go in, I shall throw myself into the Ganga.” And the Lord granted His devotee's request.

Another time the Lord ascended the throne of Vishnu in Srivasa's temple, spoke Himself of His nature and granted all their desires. Srivasa asked Him for love of God for Shachi. The Lord replied that she bore an offence against a Vaishnava — an offence at the feet of Advaita — and until she was freed of it she could not receive prema-bhakti. “If we hear such a thing once more,” said Srivasa, “the devotees will give up their lives,” and at his request the Lord explained how an offence against a Vaishnava is removed. Shachi went to Advaita and received forgiveness.

Once, at the Lord's request, Srivasa was reading the “Vishnu-sahasranama.” At the name of Nrisimha the Lord entered the mood of Nrisimha, seized a club and went through the town to beat the pashandis. The townspeople were terrified; seeing their fear, the Lord restrained His anger, returned to Srivasa's house and threw down the club.

At the Lord's command all Navadvipa sang in the evenings in every home, “(Hare) Haraye namah, Krishna Yadavaya namah, Gopala Govinda Rama Sri Madhusudana” and “Hari o Rama Rama,” with mridangas, karatalas and conches. The Kazi, hearing it, beat people, broke mridangas and ran riot from house to house.[15] Then the Lord organised a huge procession, dividing the devotees into groups, and in the town kirtana Srivasa, at the Lord's command, danced joyfully.[16] The place where the Kazi broke the mridanga was later pointed out by Jagannatha Dasa Babaji: it is called “Khola-bhangar-danga,” “the place where the mridanga was broken,” and it is none other than Srivasa-angana.

When Nityananda and Haridasa, having run from two drunkards, told the Lord about them, Gangadasa and Srivasa, who were sitting before Him, explained who they were: “O Lord, their names are Jagai and Madhai. They are sons of a pious brahmana and were born here. Bad company has spoiled them” (CB, Madhya 13.121–123). And after Madhai wounded Nityananda, the Lord with the devotees brought the brothers to Srivasa-angana, and there they became devotees.

Once the Lord displayed wondrous transformations in Shuklambara's house, and among those who saw them were Gadadhara, Sadashiva, Murari, Srivasa and Shriman; after Gaya, Shriman, Srivasa, Gadadhara and Sadashiva were with Shuklambara.

In the time when Advaita lived in Navadvipa — from the Lord's self-revelation until His sannyasa — he came every day to the kirtana in Srivasa-angana. Once he danced there sadly, lamenting that he had not attained the highest. In loving delirium he said to the Lord: “Neither I nor Srivasa have attained love of God… We have no access to prema, while this Avadhuta has come and become its keeper” (CB, Madhya 17.22–23). And when the Lord, having resolved to drown Himself, was saved by Nityananda and Haridasa and took refuge with Nandana, the devotees suffered without Him. The Lord asked Nandana to bring Srivasa alone;[17] Srivasa told Him that Advaita in despair was fasting, and begged the Lord to appear to him and to the others who were suffering, and the Lord went with him to Advaita.

Before the Lord's sannyasa Srivasa and Murari came to Him, and He consoled them (“Chaitanya-mangala”). A song of Vamshivadana laments that He will no longer dance with the devotees in Srivasa's temple.

The Death of His Son

To show what a true Vaishnava householder and pure devotee is, the Lord displayed this pastime in Srivasa's house. The kirtana was going on when, in the evening, about an hour after sunset, Srivasa's only son died of an illness; weeping was heard from the inner rooms.

Srivasa went in to the women, saw that his son had gone, and, deep in devotion and knowing the truth, began to comfort them: “Whoever hears His name even once before the end goes to Krishna's abode, be he even a great sinner. And here the Lord Himself is dancing with His associates — He Whose glory Brahma and Shiva sing. We should not grieve but wish such good fortune for ourselves.” Without Krishna's will, he said, not a blade of grass moves; Krishna gives life and Krishna takes it away, and to oppose His will brings only sorrow; listen to Krishna's name. “But if, giving way to worldly feeling, you cannot hold back your tears — weep later. If your weeping draws the Lord out of His ecstasy, I shall throw myself into the Ganga.”

His words calmed everyone: the women, forgetting the dead, listened to the kirtana till late at night, and Srivasa joyfully returned to the Lord and danced.

The Lord said: “Today something is wrong in My heart. Has some misfortune happened in the Pandita's house?” Srivasa replied: “What misfortune can there be where Your face is and Your sweet kirtana?” But other Vaishnavas told of the death. “Why did you not tell Me?” — “Srivasa forbade it, so as not to disturb Your joy in the kirtana.” And Srivasa said: “Only the body has died. Were the whole universe to die, I am happy looking at You; to interrupt Your kirtana would be worse than death to me.”

The Lord wept, calling the names “Govinda! Govinda!”, and said:

“How can I part from one who does not grieve over his son's death out of love for Me?” (CB, Madhya 25.52)

In these words there was a hint of the coming sannyasa and of separation from the devotees, and the intimate devotees understood it.

The Lord sat down beside the body, touched it and addressed the dead boy: “Why are you leaving Srivasa's house?” Life returned to the body, and the child answered: “No one has power against Your will. Who is whose father, who is whose son? Each receives a body according to his karma. As long as it was destined for me, I lived in the house of Srivasa-prabhu; now I go to another place. Be merciful, that I may not forget Your feet; I bow to You and Your associates. Many times I have been born and

died, but this time I die seeing Your feet — and I go away happy."

Hearing the truth from the child's lips, Srivasa's family forgot their grief and, weeping now with love, embraced the Lord's feet:

"Birth after birth You are our father, mother, son and teacher. Never let us forget Your lotus feet. O Lord, it does not matter where we are born. Only keep in us forever loving devotion to Your lotus-like feet." (CB, Madhya 25.70–71)

Srivasa fell at the Lord's feet in tears of rapture.

The Lord said to him: "You know how the world is. These inevitable worldly sorrows will touch neither you nor anyone who sees you. From this day I and Nityananda are your eternal sons; We shall not leave you. Remember this, and you will know no grief for a son." Thus Chaitanya and Nityananda became debtors to Their devotee. Then the Lord with all the devotees carried the dead boy with kirtana to the Ganga and performed the funeral rites. Service to the Lord and His joy were for Srivasa above his own grief — in this lies the example of a true Vaishnava householder.

Kumarahatta

Srivasa lived in Mayapur throughout Gaurasundara's Navadvipa pastimes. But when the Lord took sannyasa, Srivasa could not bear the separation: in Navadvipa everything was a painful reminder of the Lord. With his brothers and his whole family he left his house and settled in Kumarahatta (Halisahar),[18] in the Mukhopadhyaya-para quarter, near the birthplace of Ishvara Puri — the "Chaitanya-doba." A temple called "Devalaya," facing the Chaitanya-doba, marks the place where he lived. In Kumarahatta lived also Shivananda Sena, Khanja Bhagavan Dasa, and Vasudeva Datta, the closest friend of Srivasa and Shivananda, who settled near them in Kanchanpalli. From here the brothers went every year to Nilachala to the Lord, and sometimes to Mayapur to Shachi, and then they would stay a few days in their old house.

The Lord came to Srivasa in Kumarahatta from Advaita's house in Shantipura.[19] Having visited the birthplace of His guru, He took a handful of earth and tied it in the end of His cloth. Srivasa, seeing before his eyes the One on Whom he had meditated, fell prostrate, pressed the Lord's feet to his chest and wept aloud. Hearing of the Lord's arrival, there came Purandara Acharya, whom the Lord called His father, and then Vasudeva Datta Thakura, Shivananda Sena with his family and other associates of Gaura (CB, Antya 5.15–18), and all of Srivasa's household joyfully served the Lord and His associates.

The Lord stayed several days with Srivasa. Srivasa delighted Him with kirtana, with reading the "Bhagavatam," and with jokes, like a vidushaka, and Ramai, following his brother, sang the Lord's glories. In Srivasa's house in Kumarahatta the Lord glorified Vasudeva Datta: "This body belongs to Vasudeva…". From here He went to Panihati, to the house of Raghava Pandita.

Once the Lord asked: "You never go anywhere to earn money — how do you maintain so large a family?" Srivasa answered: "I have no inclination to seek money. What is destined will be." — "Then take sannyasa." — "I cannot." — "Neither sannyasa nor money — what will you do if nothing comes of itself?" Srivasa clapped his hands three times: "One, two, three. If after three days of fasting there is still no food, I shall tie a pot to my neck and enter the Ganga."

The Lord roared: "What did you say, Srivasa? You, starve for want of money? Even if Lakshmi should go begging, one who has surrendered will know no want. Have you forgotten My promise in the 'Gita'?" And He recalled it: to those who always think of Him and serve Him, He Himself brings what they lack and preserves what they have (Gita 9.22). "I Myself carry on My head all that is needed by those who have surrendered to Me and serve Me. To one who, forgetting body and home, always thinks

of Me and does not go begging at others' doors, all perfections come. Dharma, wealth, desires and liberation come of themselves to serve My servant, but he does not ask for them. My Sudarshana guards him everywhere and always; he does not perish even at the great dissolution of the world; I sustain even one who remembers My servant. Sit at home and sing My glories — everything will come of itself." Thus the Lord repeated the blessing He had given in Navadvipa: "There will never be want in your house." And Ramai He told to serve his elder brother in every way.

In Nilachala

While the Lord lived in Nilachala, Srivasa came there every year with the other devotees from Bengal and stayed for the four months of the rains. Krishnadasa Kaviraja lists them: Advaita, Nityananda, Mukunda, Srivasa, Vidyanidhi, Vasudeva and Murari came every year and stayed there four months (CC, Madhya 1.255). The news that the Lord had returned from the South — brought by Kala Krishnadasa — brought back to life Shachi, Srivasa, Advaita and Haridasa, and they began to prepare for Puri. In the third year the wives went with their husbands — and Malini went with Srivasa; among the pilgrims of that year are named Acharyaratna, Vidyanidhi, Srivasa and Ramai (CC, Madhya 16.16, 22–23).

When the Bengali devotees first came to Puri, King Prataparudra watched them from the roof of his palace, and Gopinatha Acharya, who knew them all from Navadvipa-Mayapur, named each of them at his request and spoke in more detail of the chief ones — Advaita, Srivasa and others (CC, Madhya 11.84).

In Nilachala Srivasa danced in the Lord's kirtana and before the chariot, washed the Gundicha temple together with all the others, took part in the water pastimes in Narendra Lake and served the Lord in many ways, and the Lord sometimes took His meals in his house and in the houses of other householder devotees.

At the Ratha-yatra the Lord divided the devotees into groups:

"Advaita Acharya was appointed the dancer of the first group. Then the Lord formed the second group, in which the lead singer was Srivasa. Gangadasa, Haridasa, Shriman, Shubhananda and Sri Rama Pandita were to sing with Srivasa, and the dancer was Sri Nityananda." (CC, Madhya 13.38–39)

The chief singers at the Ratha-yatra were Svarupa Damodara and Srivasa; there were four groups, with six singers and two mridangas in each. And when the Lord Himself danced, nine sang for Him, whom He gave to Svarupa Damodara's group: Srivasa, Ramai, Raghu, Govinda, Mukunda, Haridasa, Govindananda, Madhava and another Govinda — by one of the biographies, Govinda Ghosha (CC, Madhya 13.73–74). In the kirtana at the Lord's residence, in four groups, the dancers were Nityananda, Advaita, Vakreshvara and Srivasa, and each felt that the Lord was looking at him; in the great kirtana around the temple there were seven groups, each with its own dancer — Advaita, Nityananda, Vakreshvara, Achyutananda, Srivasa, Satyaraja and Narahari (CC, Antya 10.58–61).[20]

Once King Prataparudra was watching the Lord's dance, leaning on the shoulder of his minister Harichandana. Srivasa stood in ecstasy in front of the king, his eyes fixed on the Lord. Harichandana touched him again and again and asked him to move aside, but Srivasa did not understand; at last, vexed at this hindrance to his service, he slapped Harichandana. Harichandana grew angry and wanted to respond, but the king stopped him:

"'You should be happy that you have been blessed by Srivasa's touch. That good fortune has passed me by, and therefore you should be grateful to him.'" (CC, Madhya 13.97)

Srivasa is an intimate associate of Gaura, and even a hurt or a blow from such a Vaishnava is good fortune and true honour.

On the fifth day after the Ratha-yatra Hera-panchami is celebrated: Lakshmi goes to Gundicha to “see” (heriya) Jagannatha, and her maidservants bind His servants. Svarupa Damodara, wishing to show the superiority of the love of the residents of Vraja, told the Lord that he had never heard of such anger in love as Lakshmi's: an offended gopi takes off her ornaments and silently scratches the ground with her nail, while Lakshmi, flaunting her wealth, goes to war against her beloved.

Svarupa Damodara was a servant of Radha, and Srivasa a servant of Lakshmi-Narayana, and a dispute arose between them. Srivasa said laughing: “Look, Damodara, how much wealth my Lakshmi has! And what is there in Vrindavana? Flowers, shoots, minerals, peacock feathers and gunja. Jagannatha went off to Sundarachala to look at such a Vrindavana — no wonder Lakshmi is angry. Her maidservants have bound Jagannatha's servants and exacted bows and fines from them: your Master has left such wealth and gone off for leaves and fruits! Your mistress and her friends are cowherd girls who churn butter, while mine sits on a jewelled throne, served by crowds of servants.” The devotees of Gaura who follow the path of raga could not keep from laughing at the words of Srivasa, in whom was the nature of Narada.

The Lord explained the difference: “Srivasa, in you is the nature of Narada — the sense of majesty, aishvarya; but Svarupa Damodara is a pure resident of Vraja, he knows nothing of majesty, his life is pure love.” And Svarupa answered Srivasa: “Listen carefully: you have forgotten the wealth of Vrindavana. The wealth of Maha-Vaikuntha is but a drop of its natural wealth; there Krishna, setting majesty aside, is rich in the sweetness of leaves and flowers, there is an eternal forest of spiritual wish-fulfilling trees…” — and he described the sweetness and majesty of Vraja with verses of the “Brahma-samhita.” Srivasa clapped his hands, roared with laughter and danced in the ecstasy of love. So this dispute revealed the superiority of the love of Vraja over reverential devotion.

Once in Nilachala Srivasa and other devotees began to sing the glories of the qualities of Gaurasundara Himself. The Lord grew angry: “You have abandoned the name and qualities of Krishna! You want to show your audacity — you are wilfully ruining the world.” At that moment cries rose on every side from countless people:

“All glory to Mahaprabhu Sri Chaitanya, the son of King Nanda! You have descended to deliver this whole world. O Lord, we are very unfortunate. We have come from afar to see You. We beg You, shower Your mercy upon us!” (CC, Madhya 1.273–274)

The Lord came out to them, and all began to glorify Him as Bhagavan. Srivasa did not miss his chance and reproached Him: “Why didn't You stay hidden in the house now? Who taught this crowd to glorify You? Cover all their mouths with Your hands! Can one hide the sunrise with a hand?” And the Lord, Who increases the glory of His devotees, admitted Himself defeated by His devotee.

Even after the Lord settled in Puri, He still appeared in Bengal:

“The Lord is always attracted by divine love, for such is His nature. Therefore Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu always manifested Himself in four places: in the household temple of mother Shachi, in the place where Nityananda Prabhu dances, during the kirtana of Srivasa Thakura, and in the house of Raghava Pandita.” (CC, Antya 2.34)

Svarupa Damodara was, in the words of Krishnadasa Kaviraja, “the soul of the whole community of devotees headed by Srivasa Thakura” (CC, Madhya 10.117). And when the Lord was in Ramakeli, His company included Nityananda, Haridasa, Srivasa, Gadadhara, Mukunda, Jagadananda, Murari and Vakreshvara; at the Lord's command Rupa and Sanatana touched their feet, and they blessed the

brothers. Srivasa was also among the Lord's associates when Lokanatha came to Him.

In Puri Srivasa also asked the Lord about Junior Haridasa. Back in Navadvipa a Vaishnava from Prayaga had brought news that Haridasa had entered the Triveni, and Srivasa and the others were amazed. A year later, in Puri, Srivasa asked where Haridasa was now. “Each tastes the fruit of his own deeds,” the Lord replied; and when Srivasa told what he had heard, the Lord said with a smile: “That is the atonement for looking at a woman.”

After the Lord's Disappearance

Srivasa outlived the Lord. When Jiva Gosvami came to Navadvipa, he met Nityananda in Srivasa's house, and Nityananda told Srivasa and others to bless Jiva (“Bhakti-ratnakara,” 1). Srinivasa Acharya too saw him in Navadvipa before his journey to Vrindavana — together with Murari Gupta, Damodara Pandita, Sanjaya, Shuklambara, Gadadhara Dasa and others. Srinivasa's mother, Lakshmipriya, when he was still an infant, taught him to sing: “…Gadadhara's master, Srivasa's Lord…”.

When Narottama planned the festival at Kheturi, Srivasa was no longer in this world: his brothers Shripati and Shrinidhi came there from Navadvipa. They brought Jahnava Devi to their house in Navadvipa, and, finding there neither Srivasa nor Malini, she wept bitterly; on the way back she spent a night in Srivasa-angana, where the Lord had begun the sankirtana, and a maha-sankirtana went on all night. In Mayapur Narottama too came to the house of Srivasa Pandita and bowed to Shripati and Shrinidhi. Yet it is said that at the Kheturi festival Mahaprabhu, Nityananda, Advaita, Haridasa, Srivasa Thakura and others, long since withdrawn from view, appeared once more and sang with the devotees as in the Lord's time. The year and place of Srivasa's departure are unknown.[21]

Srivasa-angana

In time the site of Srivasa-angana was forgotten. It was rediscovered by Jagannatha Dasa Babaji, who identified the forgotten holy places of Mayapur — the Yogapitha, Srivasa-angana and others. The “Sajjana-toshani” of Bhaktivinoda Thakura relates that on the 20th of Phalguna in the year 1299 of the Bengali era (1893)[22] the Babaji pointed out the place of the Lord's appearance, and then the place where the Kazi broke the mridanga — Srivasa-angana. It was decided to establish the service of Deities both at the birthplace and at Srivasa-angana, and the Babaji proposed installing the Deities of the Pancha-tattva here.

Fulfilling the Lord's command of unbroken sankirtana, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, at the wish of Bhaktivinoda Thakura and Jagannatha Dasa Babaji, opened at Srivasa-angana a centre for preaching sankirtana among pure devotees and for the service of Sri Pancha-tattva. At Bhaktivinoda's wish he installed the dancing Gaura in the house of Chandrashekhara Acharya, founded Sri Chaitanya Math as the main centre of sankirtana, and ordered that the “seven-tongued fire” of sankirtana be kept burning there always. In 1934 the temple buildings at Srivasa-angana were consecrated, and in 1936, on Bhaktisiddhanta's sixty-second birthday, his Vyasa-puja was held here. Srivasa-angana in Mayapur became one of the temples of the Gaudiya Math. Later Bhakti Vilasa Tirtha Maharaja, fulfilling Bhaktisiddhanta's wish, built at Srivasa-angana, next to the Advaita-bhavana, a temple of Gadadhara.

Narada and the Pancha-tattva

In Krishna's pastimes Srivasa is the sage Narada. The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” says:

“The wise Srivasa Pandita is the former sage Narada; the best of sages named Parvata, Narada's friend, is Sriman Rama Pandita, his younger brother.” (GGD 90)

Malini in Vraja is Krishna's nurse Ambika: “The nurse in Vraja named Ambika, who once suckled Him, is this Malini, considered the wife of Srivasa” (GGD 42). And Narayani is Kilimbika, Ambika's sister, who partook of Krishna's remnants (GGD 43). Srivasa is also called an avatara of Narada Muni; the nature of Narada and the sense of majesty were recognised in him by the Lord Himself in the dispute at Hera-panchami, and he came on stage as Narada in the play at Chandrashekhara's.

In the Pancha-tattva Srivasa is “the one called a devotee,” bhakta-akhya, a pure devotee. The “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” lists the five: Gaurachandra is “the devotee in form,” Nityananda “the devotee in essence,” Advaita “the incarnation of the devotee”; “Srivasa and the others are ‘those called devotees,’ for they have the form of devotees,” and “the potency of the devotee” is Gadadhara Pandita (GGD 11). Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati, in his commentary on CC, Adi 1.14, explains: all five are one in essence and differ only in five moods; Gauranga, Nityananda and Advaita are vishnu-tattva, while the shaktis and the pure devotees are His energies. The chief shaktis are Gadadhara, Svarupa Damodara and Ramananda; the pure devotees are Srivasa and others who serve the Lord in the mood of friendship and service. So too Krishnadasa Kaviraja says that Srivasa and countless devotees belong to the pure devotee-servants, while Gadadhara and others are incarnations of energies (CC, Adi 7.14–17).

The Glory of Srivasa

The biographies call Srivasa the first of the pure devotees and a constant associate of the Lord, a participant in all His important pastimes. Lochana Dasa in the “Chaitanya-mangala” names him among the associates who descended with the Lord, and the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” calls the Lord “the refuge of Srivasa and Gadadhara” (CB, Adi 9.2). Srivasa's name has entered prayers as well: “nāmi śrīmad-advaitācāryaṁ śrīvāsa-paṇḍitam…”; in the guru-parampara of the “Hari-bhakti-vilasa” Srivasa is mentioned among the authorities — “…gadādharaṁ śrīvāsaṁ bhakta-varyakam”; in explaining the “Bhagavatam” (11.5.32), Srivasa and others are named the “upangas,” the Lord's associates. Sarvabhauma's life as a householder is held up as an example by comparison with Advaita and Srivasa: for the sake of service to the Lord they set aside family and social concerns. His name stands forever in the row of the five names of the Pancha-tattva: “Krishna Chaitanya, Prabhu Nityananda, Advaita, Gadadhara, Srivasa.”

Srivasa is mentioned also in a song of Vamshivadana about Srivasa's temple, and in the account of Yadunatha Dasa about Chandrashekhara, who came from Shrihatta together with Srivasa and Srirama. The biographies recall that Jagadananda, Nandana, Buddhimanta, Jagadisha and Shuklambara attended the kirtanas at Srivasa's, and that it was in Srivasa-angana that Murari received his lesson about the order of obeisances.

The whole meaning of this life lies in the words with which the account of him closes: the Lord, Who increases the glory of His devotees, was defeated by His devotee, and therefore we sing the glory of Srivasa. Gaurasundara Himself maintains one who has surrendered to Him: there is no need to go begging at others' doors. The home where no gods other than Gaura were known became the home of His pastimes; in it even the servants, dogs and cats attained what ascetics do not attain.

1. So the “Prema-vilasa” relates: Jaladhara Pandita had five sons, the eldest of whom was Nalina Pandita, and Srivasa was the second. All other accounts speak of four brothers — Srivasa, Srirama, Shripati and Shrinidhi.

2. Whose daughter Narayani was is told differently: by some accounts, the eldest brother's, Nalina Pandita's; by others, simply “one of the brothers'”; the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” calls her the daughter of Srivasa's brother (Madhya 2.321–322). Vrindavana Dasa himself nowhere says that he is the grandson of Srivasa's brother and that Srivasa is his great-uncle, so as not to exalt himself. In one place, however, he is called the grandson of Srivasa's sister.

3. Where Narayani lived after her marriage and where Vrindavana Dasa was born is told differently. By one account, she lived in her husband's house in Kumarahatta (Halisahar) and, widowed, settled with Srivasa in Navadvipa, where the boy received the Lord's special mercy; by another, she was given in marriage in Mamgachhi, into Malini's family, and there, it

is said, Vrindavana Dasa was born; by a third, he was born in Mamgachhi or in Kumarahatta. That as a boy he grew up in the ancestral home of Malini Devi is also said in Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's commentary on the “Chaitanya-bhagavata.”

4. That the son was an only son two biographies state plainly; the third calls him simply Srivasa's son.

5. Our calendar marks the appearance day of Srivasa Pandita on Krishna-ashtami of the month of Vishnu (≈ Chaitra); his disappearance day is not in the calendar. One biography names the month of his departure Vamana, another Ashadha; these are the same month.

6. The Lord's associates are not subject to maya, the illusory energy. What for a time keeps them from recognising Him is yogamaya — the Lord's internal energy, which arranges His pastimes: not recognising God in Nimai, the devotees prayed for Him with love, and so the tastes of these pastimes came to be.

7. By one biography, the impressionable Srivasa believed the rumours about the king's boats, grew alarmed and began to worship Nrisimhadeva for protection; by another, nothing is said of fear — the Lord came because He knew the heart of His devotee.

8. One of the biographies, telling of this in its chapter on Srivasa, says nothing of a search: Mahaprabhu knew that Nityananda was at Nandana's and went there Himself with the devotees.

9. On Gaura's head, by one account, or round His neck, by another.

10. Srivasa is not saying that Nityananda acts in this way, but that no deeds of Nityananda — even those that might seem inadmissible — would shake his faith: Nityananda is the Lord's second body, and His acts are not subject to worldly judgement.

11. By another account, the crow carried off a vessel of ghee used for the worship of Vishnu in Srivasa's house.

12. By one of the biographies, the kirtana began in the evening of Ekadashi; the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Madhya 8.140) and another biography say that the Lord danced from dawn.

13. One biography places the incident at Devananda's before the Lord's appearance; the others do not date it. How Devananda was freed from his offence is also told differently: he received the Lord's mercy by serving Vakreshvara — or he came to Srivasa and was forgiven by him.

14. By one account, Srivasa told another devotee to lead her out unnoticed by the rest; by another, all the devotees searched, and Srivasa, finding his mother-in-law, was embarrassed and led her out by the hair himself. So too the first biography says elsewhere that Srivasa himself led his mother-in-law out by the hair because she had displeased the Lord, and adds that the deeds of such devotees are not to be measured by the standards of worldly society.

15. According to one of the biographies, the Kazi (Sirajuddin, Chand Kazi) came to Srivasa's house in particular, broke a mridanga there and ordered the devotees to be beaten.

16. The order of the procession is told differently: by one account, it was divided into three parts headed by Advaita, Haridasa and Srivasa, while Nityananda was with the Lord; by another, Haridasa went in front, Advaita in the middle and Gaurachandra Himself at the rear, and Srivasa together with Gadadhara, Vakreshvara, Murari, Gopinatha and countless servants went with Him.

17. By one account, the Lord asked Nandana to bring Srivasa; by another, it was Haridasa who brought Srivasa to Nandana's.

18. By one account, Srivasa moved to Kumarahatta not after the sannyasa but after Mahaprabhu's disappearance.

19. When this happened is told differently: by one account, soon after the sannyasa, from Advaita's house in Shantipura; by another (so in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”), when, five years after His sannyasa, the Lord came from Puri to Bengal to see Shachi and the Ganga and, after staying a few days with Advaita, went to Kumarahatta.

20. These are different kirtanas, and Srivasa's roles in them differ: at the Ratha-yatra he was the lead singer of the second group (CC, Madhya 13), while in the kirtana at the Lord's residence and in the great kirtana around the temple he was the dancer of his group.

21. No biography names either the year or the place of his departure. His appearance at the Kheturi festival does not contradict this: the eternal associates of the Lord, having withdrawn their pastimes from the world's sight, can manifest themselves again whenever and wherever the Lord and His devotees wish.

22. One biography gives the year 1892 here; but the Bengali year 1299 began in April 1892, and its month of Phalguna falls in February–March 1893.